Name: RISK 7.2 - AI has dangerous capabilities

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2024-05-27 - RNZ - New Zealand continues to call> - § 1 reference coded [8.86% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 8.86% Coverage

The world's militaries are increasingly using drones in the air, on land and at sea. Almost a dozen countries have announced drone swarm programmes, where dozens or more drones coordinate. Artificial intelligence is increasingly added to the mix. While not all AWS use AI, "rapid recent advances in technologies such as machine learning and AI ... mean that AWS are now potentially much more mobile, versatile, capable and lethal," a briefing to government ministers in January said.
Not all of of the systems are lethal.

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2024-07-03 - RNZ - AI for school tutoring, instan> - § 1 reference coded [2.40% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 2.40% Coverage

In his 2021 book Scary Smart Mo Gawdat, formerly chief business officer of Google X, predicts that by 2049 AI will be a billion times smarter than the smartest human. The gap in intelligence would be similar to that between a fly and Einstein, leading Gawdat to ask, how do you convince the superbeing not to squash the fly?

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2024-07-25 - RNZ - Killer robot advisory group sh> - § 3 references coded [12.55% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 3.60% Coverage

"This is a very disappointing development at the precise moment that we are seeing AI-equipped weapons being used on battlefields in various conflicts," said Gregory. "It's very disappointing to see the government seemingly abandon its efforts to regulate these weapons." MFAT told RNZ in May that "technological advancements in the areas of autonomy are moving quickly".

Reference 2 - 3.42% Coverage

But Gregory said the time for critical questions was now, including if people wanted the New Zealand Defence Force to serve alongside autonomous-weapon equipped militaries. "The stakes could not be higher," he said. "This technology has the capacity to accelerate the violence that's inflicted on the battlefield and amplify the potential for mistakes."

Reference 3 - 5.53% Coverage

War has cut the technical barriers dramatically, as in Ukraine, with its robot machineguns and kamikaze drones. "While these weapons aren't as advanced as expensive military-grade systems made by the United States, China and Russia, what makes the developments significant is their low cost - just thousands of dollars or less - and ready availability," the New York Times reported.
A machinegun maker told the Times he could modify the gun to remove the human element of a soldier pulling the trigger entirely, with a quick tweak so the gun would aim and fire itself.

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2024-08-02 - RNZ - NZ joins US military exercises> - § 2 references coded [3.43% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 1.26% Coverage

The Defence Force has been helping the US military with artificial intelligence-powered weapons to speed up what they call "kill chains".

Reference 2 - 2.17% Coverage

AI is supercharging not just the race to develop non-lethal autonomous systems, such as in targeting, but potentially lethal ones, too, at a time when the UN is struggling to find consensus around international limits on killer robots.

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2025-03-18 - RNZ - The future of warfare- Killer> - § 2 references coded [4.06% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 1.88% Coverage

It comes at the same time as Ukrainian soldiers fleeing Russia's Kursk region have spoken of being "hunted down" by two or three drones at a time. In return, Ukrainians are deploying 'dragon drones' that spew molten metal at 4400 degrees on top of the Russian front lines, before crashing.

Reference 2 - 2.18% Coverage

The Ukraine war shows the inverse - drones are not taking the hit, they are delivering it.
Commanders there have estimated drones were dealing out 70 percent of deaths and casualties, the New York Times reported in an article headlined, 'Drones now rule the battlefield'. The integration is now going further with AI, at a fast pace.

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2025-03-19 - SCP - Where Does NZ Stand On Killer> - § 2 references coded [3.24% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 1.40% Coverage

Drones have become the biggest killer on Ukraine's battlefields, an AI targeting system is telling triggermen who to hit in Gaza, and in the US, the Pentagon has signalled its strongest embrace of generative AI yet.

Reference 2 - 1.84% Coverage

"For example, militaries are already using AI, which means the international community is going to need to develop new norms about how this is done in a way that ensures compliance with the rules of war and ensures human responsibility in conflict," he said at the Raisina Dialogue.

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2025-03-20 - RNZ - Military robots and thinking t> - § 5 references coded [11.18% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 2.64% Coverage

Project Convergence Capstone, that is running this month in the California desert, is the Americans' number one experimentation exercise with military robots.
The US army is on the verge of awarding a big contract for a robot vehicle with guns that would go ahead of infantry to surveil and kill enemy soldiers.

It has just taken delivery of a prototype AI-driven targeting truck from tech firm Palantir.

Reference 2 - 1.59% Coverage

Ministerial briefings state the country's position on military AI was that "we need to preserve access to technology relevant for our national security" but any new weapons should comply with international humanitarian law, an OIA response shows.

Reference 3 - 2.05% Coverage

"We can employ it .... in sensors and help us understand, when you add in the power of data and aided target recognition, AI, we also have an opportunity to protect .... and then also to kill and have an impact lethally in a ravage size," said one US commander in a video about 'human machine integrated formations'.

Reference 4 - 2.36% Coverage

"Given the US changes .... the value of supporting voluntary efforts on military use of AI - especially on autonomous weapon systems
(AWS) - and to ensure we are part of important discussions alongside partners, we recommend that New Zealand endorse the Political Declaration," the Defence Ministry told the Defence and Foreign Affairs ministers in February 2024.

Reference 5 - 2.53% Coverage

"This position recognises that we need to preserve access to technology relevant for our national security and interoperability with our security partners, while also advocating for the agreement of new rules and limits on AWS.
"It remains in our national security interests to ensure that any new weapons fielded comply with international humanitarian law and relevant ethical standards."

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2025-04-01 - RNZ - No armed drones in NZDF arsena> - § 2 references coded [17.86% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 5.39% Coverage

"We have been involved in experiments and activities to better understand how armed drones can be utilised and how to counter them," the NZDF told RNZ. "Future participation in such activities is likely."
The Civil Aviation Authority said it was not aware of any civilian operators using or planning to test weaponised drones.

Reference 2 - 12.48% Coverage

A Perth company unveiled a midsized drone last week - it has a 1.5kg warhead and can travel up to 45km, with cameras for intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance.
"Innovaero is rapidly establishing a sovereign capability for loitering munitions that will outperform any rival in the world," the company said. Australian soldiers were expected to be equipped this year with another kamikaze drone - the Switchblade 300. The government said because autonomous weapons were "increasingly prevalent", Australia had to respond.
The Australian Army's research centre said it needed sovereign capability, and to harness data from Ukraine and other theatres to "refine capabilities, adapt and improve uncrewed systems in response to real-world challenges".

<Files\\Processed x Highly relevant\\2025-04-09 - RNZ - There should always be a human> - § 4 references coded [5.67% Coverage]

Reference 1 - 0.89% Coverage

The defence minister has given the NZ military permission to acquire killer drones - provided a human is operating them and they only kill other soldiers.

Reference 2 - 2.20% Coverage

Some of the new drones will be nastier, but within limits, Defence Minister Judith Collins told Morning Report on Tuesday. "We are very clear though, we will not have what's called those drones that actually use AI to go around hunting people," Collins said. "No, that's not what we're going [sic]. "We're talking about things where it's drones to defend us against other drones."

Reference 3 - 1.67% Coverage

Canberra, which has had a focus on drones for years, is now stocking up on lethal drones. Australian defence industry minister Pat Conroy talked about the human-guided Switchblade 300 last year, calling it a "kamikaze" drone. It "loiters" over a target before dropping on it like a bomb.

Reference 4 - 0.90% Coverage

While a kamikaze drone is still human controlled, the global industry that provides AI-enabled drones is booming, and these can increasingly be autonomous.